

» TOURNAMENT REVIEW DULEEP TROPHY



Red-letter day: Central Zone won its first Duleep Trophy title since 2014-15 by defeating South Zone by six wickets.

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A tradition tested by modern priorities

The Duleep Trophy 2025 showcased emerging talent but struggled with absent stars, empty stands, and questions over its **relevance** in a packed cricket calendar.

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Just a couple of months before V.V.S. Laxman and Rahul Dravid stunned the world with their 376-run fifth-wicket stand against Australia at Eden Gardens in 2001, the duo engaged in a dress rehearsal.

The preview show came in Surat, where Laxman and Dravid added 409 runs for the third wicket in a Duleep Trophy match between South Zone and West Zone.

At that time, the Duleep Trophy still attracted household names, as reflected in the team lists. Apart from Laxman and Dravid, South boasted several internationals — Sadagoppan Ramesh, Sunil Joshi, S. Sriram,

Hemang Badani and Venkatapathy Raju, to name a few.

West, too, fielded a formidable eleven, with the likes of Wasim Jaffer, Vinod Kambli, Nayan Mongia, Hrishikesh Kanitkar and Ajit Agarkar taking the field with pride.

Such stellar line-ups were commonplace, for the Duleep Trophy held tremendous value. For fringe players, it was the gateway to an India call-up; for established internationals, it provided the perfect competitive match practice.

The sheen fades

Cut to the present, and the scenario is vastly different. The 2025-26 edition, held at the BCCI Centre of Excellence (CoE) grounds in Bengaluru, lacked sheen and purpose.

Many India stars skipped the tournament in preparation for the T20 Asia Cup, currently underway in the UAE. Others, like Arshdeep Singh and Kuldeep Yadav, played the opening round before being summoned to the national camp.

Shubman Gill, the Test captain, was named North Zone skipper but pulled out before the opening game due to illness.

South Zone was without Mohammed Siraj, K.L. Rahul, Sai Sudharsan, Prasidh Krishna and Washington Sundar. With no official explanation given, the general belief was that they had been rested.

The venue, used in senior domestic competition for the first time, was far from ideal. Located on the outskirts of the city, the ground was out of